

Week 5: Maps and (Counter)Mappings

What appears on maps? What is left on them? What do gaps in mapping tell us about wider structures? And, what digital strategies exist to fill those gaps?

(Niamh & Gabriel)

Readings:

- Katherine McDonough, “[Maps as Data](#),” in *Computational Humanities*, 2024
- Crystal Nicole Eddins, “[Fugitivities and Futures: Black Studies in the Digital Era](#),” in *Computational Humanities*, 2024
- Jeremy Hsu, “Google Earth risked ruin with retracted AI tool for making fake satellite pics,” *Ars Technica*, July 31, 2026. [Google Map AI news item](#)

Strings / themes

This week’s readings touch on the issues of representation: who gets represented, who controls that representation, and when should we trust it?

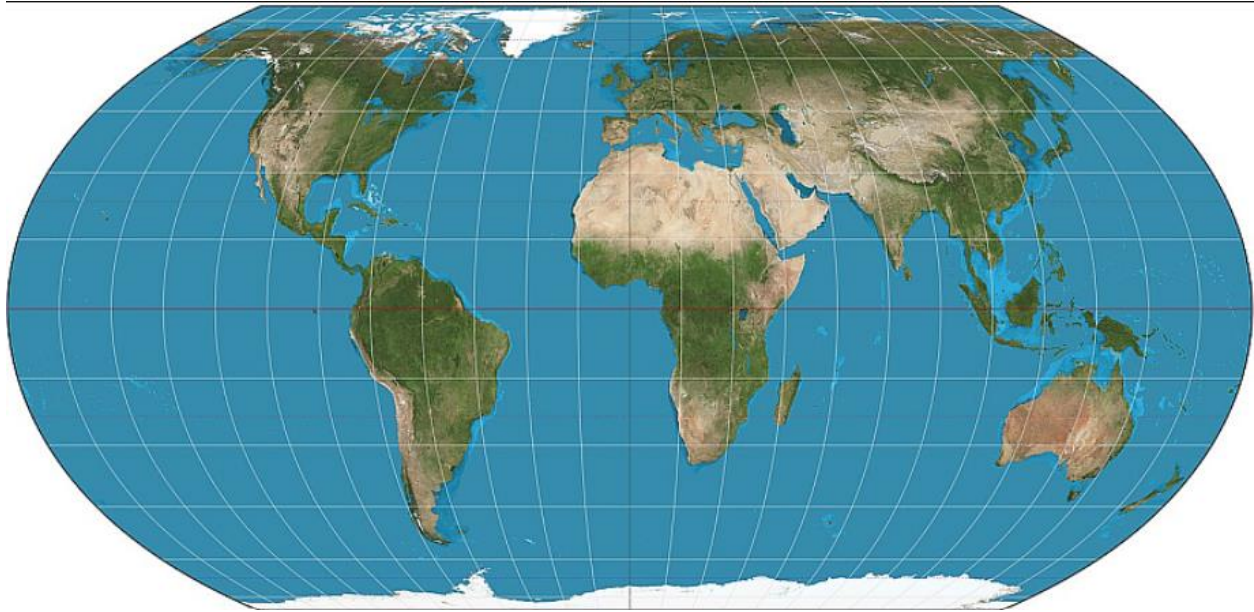
- Maps and archives make certain places, people, and experiences visible while leaving others out. These gaps can reflect exclusion, limited knowledge, or deliberate concealment.
- Recording bodies, movements, and relationships can enable control, as Eddins shows through advertisements seeking the capture of enslaved people. Those records can also be interpreted to recover histories of resistance.
- Turning maps into data and generating realistic images both require examining how representations are produced. Classifying features in historical maps and inventing visual scenes are different operations, with different evidentiary implications.

A shared question we came across the readings is: What does it mean to “fill a gap”, and should every gap be filled?

Representation: The UN’s “Correct the Map” Initiative

Very recently, on 4 September 2026, the UN General Assembly adopted a Togo-led resolution promoting equal-area projections such as Equal Earth. Mercator enlarges regions toward the poles, making Africa appear disproportionately small relative to them. Equal Earth preserves relative areas, offering a more accurate comparison of continents’ sizes. The initiative raises questions about how familiar maps shape geographical knowledge and perceptions of global importance.

Power, colonialism, and violence are the driven forces of understanding how world maps are established in the geopolitical scene.



- General Assembly Adopts Text to ‘Correct the Map’, among Others Proclaiming Decade of Culture for Sustainable Development, Child Marriage Elimination Day <https://press.un.org/en/2026/ga12779.doc.htm>

UVA mapping

Below are some examples of how UVA has been mapped for either historical or public purposes:

- ★ **Cville Sanborn:** <https://geoportal.lib.virginia.edu/UVASanbornDiscovery/>
 - “Originally published by the Sanborn Map Company (Sanborn), they were created to allow fire insurance companies to assess their total liability in urbanized areas of the United States...the company became the largest and most successful American map company. This growth came about through savvy management and the buyout of competing firms” (Wiki).
- ★ **UVA Visitor Map:** [click here](#)
- ★ **UVA Obscura:** <https://www.virginia.edu/obscura/>
 - “UVA Obscura, a product of UVA Communication’s Digital Strategy team, uncovers the hidden stories behind lesser-known objects on Grounds” (UVAToday)
- ★ **Interactive study space map:** <https://www.uvastudco.com/study-spaces>
- ★ **Campus Illustrated Maps:** <https://illustratedmaps.com/portfolio/uva-campus-illustrated-map>

About Illustrated Maps created by Rabinky Art, LLC

While a bird's eye view is something today we're treated to via satellite mapping, the technique of creating oblique map art dates back well into the 1600's – much earlier than satellites or even photography. Today we realize that the old style is an excellent way to communicate the scale, design elements, orientation, and navigation in a single, artistic image created by a professional map illustrator.

Grid-style maps may be helpful, but they are rarely attractive. Using illustrated elements in a color 2-D map or 3-D illustrated maps allows campuses or towns to be presented with the shapes and colors we've come to expect in real life. With the vitality and energy that only 3-D images can create, an actual birds-eye view map breathes life into any area.



Take a moment (with your partner) to think about the following:

1. In looking at the examples, think about a place at UVA or in Charlottesville that matters to you. Find it on each map. How is it represented?
2. How do you think the information on each map was collected?
3. Which of these maps would you *trust* to represent Grounds? What makes a map trustworthy to you?

Reflection: mapping and collaboration

Digital mapping has the ability to make neglected places and experiences visible, while countermapping can question the dominant representations. However, this also brings up issues concerning who determines the aim of a project, which knowledge is considered valid, and what is made public. When it comes to collaboration, it is necessary to discuss these decisions with the people involved, since different communities may have different views, priorities, and reasons for keeping some knowledge private.

What would be the way of working with communities in your own area to produce digital maps or counter-maps which reflect their knowledge, question the current representations, and enable the participants to decide what is shown, what is shared and what remains unmapped?

Community Mapping: Definitions and Instances

By using community mapping, archaeological research is able to enter into dialogue with the knowledge of those who live in a particular landscape. It involves combining activities such as walking, having conversations, collecting oral histories, taking photographs, and drawing maps together with digital techniques. The people taking part in this process help to decide which places are important, how they are understood, and what information should be made available.

This method takes into account the fact that landscapes can be understood in various ways: while an earthwork has definite dimensions, it can also be linked to memories, spiritual significance, ordinary activities, and histories of belonging. These interpretations differ between and within communities. Digital archaeology creates a contradiction since GIS and remote sensing break

down landscapes into categories which may simplify those relationships. The issue then is to make use of digital techniques while at the same time allowing the communities to determine the categories and interpretations themselves. This is related to McDonough's concern regarding the preservation of context when converting maps into data. "Maps as Data."

Instance: Sacred Landscapes Amazonian Archaeology Project – Pando, Bolivia: This project combines archaeological research with drones and LiDAR to address issues of movement, memory, and current relationships with these areas.



Community mapping initiative with Loma Alta community in Pando, Bolivian Amazonia. Personal Picture, 2025.

Community mapping could advance this kind of work by means of a shared interpretation of images, significant routes, place names, and local accounts. It can take the form of countermapping when it questions dominant representations, for example those which depict Amazonia as an untouched landscape. Moreover, collaboration also involves making decisions as to who controls the resulting information and what should remain private or unmapped.



Training in fundamentals and methodologies of anthropology, archaeology, ecology, and the use of specific technologies like GPS and Drones was conducted in 2022 and 2023 in Beni, Bolivian Amazonia. Jaimes Betancourt et al (2025).

Resources

- <https://www.earthdefenderstoolkit.com/home/>; Earth Defenders Toolkit: Community examples and practical resources for mapping territories and cultural knowledge.
- <https://terrastories.app/>; Terrastories: Connects oral histories and audiovisual recordings to places, with offline access and restricted-sharing options.
- <https://www.gida-global.org/careprinciples>; CARE Principles: Indigenous data governance focused on collective benefit, authority, responsibility, and ethics.
- <https://localcontexts.org/labels/traditional-knowledge-labels/>; Local Contexts: Labels communicating community protocols for attribution, access, and reuse.

Application

Below are the details for joining a Mentimeter, which will be used for a live audience poll. We will display the poll during class at the end of our discussion and will answer on your own devices. This will help us understand how different students and departments envision using the information we discussed today. How can we learn from the approaches and creative thinking of our peers?

Follow the link: <https://www.menti.com/?code=55665565>

Or

Go to **Menti.com**

Joining code is **5566 5565**